Nottingham School of Art & Design

Design & Digital Arts Practice Fund 25/26: criteria and guidance

The Design & Digital Arts (D&DA) Practice Fund supports the exploration and sharing of practice-based outputs that do not necessarily lead directly to commercial income. This fund is intended for small-scale, practice-led projects that test and showcase the potential of our new D&DA facilities, in collaboration with an external partner (outside the Department of Design & Digital Arts). This is not a research funding call. Instead, it forms part of our Knowledge Exchange (KE) agenda, supporting collaborative, creative endeavours that translate your expertise and practice into tangible benefits for society, the economy, and NSAD.

Linking to Departmental KE Priorities

Projects must demonstrate alignment with at least one of the Department of Design & Digital Arts' three KE priorities for 2025:

1. **Creative Solutions** – enhancing external engagement and fostering innovation and growth through collaborative efforts (*e.g. working with a business, cultural partner, or community to test a new idea or application of D&DA facilities)*
2. **Creative Graduates** – connecting students with industry to enhance their skills and employment prospects (*e.g. involving students in project delivery through Unitemps, live briefs, or collaborative practice with industry partners)*
3. **Creative Places** – developing physical and virtual spaces that encourage collaboration and innovation (*e.g. piloting the use of D&DA's new spaces or digital environments to support external partnerships and creative outputs)*

Aims of the Fund

Projects should:

- Collaborate with industry, cultural partners, or communities to deliver commercial, cultural, or societal benefits
- Explore innovative applications of D&DA's cutting-edge facilities to create new or experimental outputs
- Show potential for wider impact through KE, laying the foundations for future funding, partnerships, or opportunities

Scope of Funding

We are seeking to support small, timely projects responding to emerging opportunities. Applications may request up to £1,000 (smaller requests are welcomed). All awarded funds must be spent by the end of July 2026 (end of the financial year).

- **Eligible costs**:
  - Project costs (materials, space hire, travel, consumables)
  - Payment to staff/students via Unitemps, managed by the applicant
  - Modest contributions to dissemination activity (e.g. showcasing outputs)
- **Not eligible costs**:
  - Capital expenditure (e.g. equipment purchases).
  - Research administration
  - Outreach programmes primarily aimed at student recruitment

Staffing and Buy-Outs

Buy-out for academic staff will only be approved in exceptional circumstances. If buy-out is requested, the application must be signed off by both the relevant line manager and Head of Department before submission. Unsigned applications will be returned. Applicants are strongly encouraged to consider employing staff/students through Unitemps to deliver activity under their management.

Assessment and Outcomes

- Applications must be submitted by Friday 14th December 2025.
- Applicants will be notified of the outcome within one month of submission.

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Design & Digital Arts Practice Fund 26/26: Application form

Please note the maximum word length for each section. You can apply for up to £1000 to undertake activities in response to developing and deepening your practice (see guidance for a definition). These opportunities that will not necessarily result in commercial income.
Return to Charlotte Lucas – deadline Friday 14th December 2025.

Project Title
Doraraathara: AI Jam

Lead applicant
Name: Kristian Jones
School and/or Dept: DDA

Additional NTU co-applicants/participants
Name(s): Jen Bell
School/Dept (s): Fashion

Please provide the details of any external partner/collaborator for this project/activity
This project has 3 external partners: 1. Hot Knife Media (local animation / XR company, experienced in immersive / AI workflows) 2. Jen & Jones (local video / XR company, experienced in immersive / AI workflows) 3. The Nottingham Contemporary (local art gallery)

Please outline the activity/project (maximum 250 words)
Doraraathara: Live AI Jam is a practice-led project responding to the Creative Solution priorty exploring how generative AI can be used collaboratively, improvisationally, and transparently within live performance. Building on the speculative poem *Doraraathara,* a work concerned with AI, agency and future imaginaries, the project brings together NTU academics, Jen & Jones, Hot Knife Media, and Nottingham Contemporary to develop and present an experimental live audio-visual AI performance. The project will begin with two creative production workshops in NTU's Digital Immersive Studio, whose non-networked status enables safe experimentation with advanced AI tools. Collaborators will explore how multiple AI systems can be combined and mixed in real time. The project culminates in a 90-minute free public event at Nottingham Contemporary on the 29th March 2026 comprising a panel talk with NTU and industry collaborators and a 60-minute live AI jam, where performers generate and mix AI visuals, audio, and text.. Audience participation will be encouraged through a "prompt pit," enabling visitors to contribute ideas that feed directly into the performance. This project will: • Explore how multiple AI systems can be integrated into a single live performance environment. • Build new cross-sector knowledge through collaboration between NTU and industry partners. • Engage public audiences in experimental AI arts practice through transparent, participatory performance. • Use the findings to shape the next development phase of *Doraraathara*, including preparation for future film/immersive festival submission, and an academic conference exploring participatory AI art.

Through experimentation, collaboration, and public engagement, the project advances NTU's creative practice and contributes to the region's emerging AI-arts landscape.

Please provide a detailed budget breakdown.

Nottingham Contemporary Rental £1160 + VAT = £1392
Submission to the Aesthetica Film Festival = £49
DADA Practice Fund: £720.50
Fashion Practice Fund: £720.50

All other resources to support this project are digital, or involve equipment from the Nottingham School of Art & Design or the Digital Immersive Studio.

Project partners Jen and Jones, and Hot Knife Media have both agreed to participate in this project pro bono, and the Nottingham Contemporary are supporting with marketing and engagement of their Youth Participation Scheme as 'in kind' contributions.

Total: Maximum amount available (£1000)

Please outline how this activity will develop, deepen or strengthen relationships with external partners/collaborators (max 300 words).

Doraraathara: AI Jam project brings NTU into collaboration with Jen & Jones**,** Hot Knife Media, and Nottingham Contemporary, forming a multi-directional knowledge-exchange partnership that spans technical development, creative production, and public engagement.

Joe Bell, of Jen & Jones brings specialist expertise in immersive design, projection mapping, and translating AI-generated material into spatial contexts. Their knowledge of large-scale visual composition will shape how AI live prompted imagery responds to performers and audience prompts in real time. They will support the development of a responsive projection / 3D environments that forms the backbone of the live AI jam.

Hot Knife Media and director Simon Wallett contribute parallel expertise in AI-assisted content creation, XR workflows, real-time audiovisual systems, and pipeline integration. Their industry experience ensures that the performance setup is grounded in robust, production-level methods and that multiple AI processes can coexist within a stable, improvised performance framework.

Together, Kristian Jones, Jen Bell, Jen & Jones and Hot Knife Media will lead two three-hour development workshops in NTU's Digital Immersive Studio. Working concurrently with invited NTU academic and technical staff, they will prototype and refine the creative-technical system that enables live AI-driven performance. This offers NTU staff insight into industry workflows while providing partners a testbed for innovative, experimental approaches that would be difficult to explore in commercial settings.

Public engagement forms a core strand of the knowledge exchange.
Nottingham Contemporary will host and actively support the dissemination of the project through:

- cross-marketing to their members and wider public community
- promotion across social media channels
- direct engagement with their youth membership scheme, encouraging younger audiences to shape and participate in emerging AI arts practices

The 90-minute public event (panel + live AI jam) is intentionally designed as a shared learning space: audiences are invited to contribute prompts, influence the performance, ask questions, and gain transparent insight into AI-enabled creative processes. This reciprocal engagement ensures that knowledge flows not only between NTU and its partners, but also between practitioners and the public, supporting broader cultural understanding of experimental AI performance, and positioning the Nottingham School of Art and Design as innovators within this space.

How will you know whether you have achieved your objectives? Please outline relevant data, testimonial evidence, key indicators that you will collect that will demonstrate success in an evaluation plan (max 300 words).

Evaluation will focus on five interconnected areas: creative development, technical effectiveness, partnership impact, public engagement, and onward dissemination. Each area includes specific methods for gathering and analysing evidence.

1. Creative Development – evaluating artistic success

We will assess how effectively the live performance integrates multiple AI systems into a cohesive improvisational experience. Key measures include:

- **Coherence**: the thematic and aesthetic alignment of the live-mixed audio, text, and visuals.
- **Plurality**: the distinctiveness of each AI system's contribution.
- **Responsiveness**: how smoothly human performers and AI processes interact in real time.

Method: Video documentation of rehearsals and performance, reflective notes, and post-workshop debriefs with partners.

2. Technical & Workflow Effectiveness – evaluating the system itself

Success indicators include:

- Stability and reliability of live AI generation.
- Functionality of projection-mapping and real-time mixing.
- Smooth integration of audience prompts into the system.
- Reduced latency and improved synchronisation after workshop refinement.

Method: Rehearsal testing, issue tracking, and a final workflow review with industry partners.

3. Public Engagement – evaluating audience impact

The event at Nottingham Contemporary is central to evaluation. Measures include:

- Attendance numbers and demographic reach (including youth scheme participation).
- Levels of engagement in the prompt pit and live element contributions.
- Audience feedback on clarity, enjoyment, accessibility, and insight into AI processes.
- Observations of audience behaviour during the performance (dwell time, return visits, emotional reactions).

Method: Short qualitative facilitated conversations with student research assistants (L6 Fashion Marketing and Branding students), prompt-pit reflections, voice-note and post-it note feedback.

4. Partnership Impact – evaluating KE success

We will measure:

- The effectiveness of collaborative workshops for shared problem-solving.
- Innovations or insights that arise from cross-sector collaboration.
- Partner appetite for future joint projects.

Method: End-of-project interviews, or written reflections

5. Documentation & Dissemination – evaluating ongoing value

All collected data, creative reflections, technical notes, audience inputs, and partner insights, will be consolidated into a digital project evaluation document**.**

This will support:

- Development of the next iteration of *Doraraathara* for festival submission
- Identification of future research questions
- A submission to an appropriate academic or creative-technology conference exploring AI participatory art**,** extending the project's impact beyond the event itself

If your proposal includes any buy-out of staff time, you must have sign-off from the relevant line managers and HoD - relevant applications without this will be returned.

Line manager: Kathryn Coates

HoD: Claire Lockwood

Associate Dean for Practice: Guy Bingham